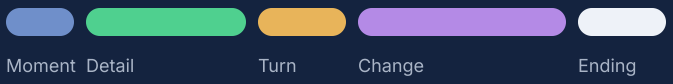
Admitted




A free guide for college applicants

# Anatomy of a winning essay.

What admissions readers look for, the shape of an essay that works, one example taken apart, and a checklist for before you submit.

01 · What readers look for

# Every reader is asking six questions.

Your grades and scores already told them what you've done. The essay is the one place they hear how you think. These six decide whether it lands.

### Could only you have written it?

Details and observations no other applicant has. Swap in a classmate's name: if it still works, it's not there yet.

### Does it sound like a person?

Plain, specific sentences in your own voice. No brochure language, no thesaurus words.

### Does it show how you think?

A real change in how you see or act, earned by what happened. Not a lesson announced at the end.

### Does the opening pull you in?

The first lines put the reader inside a moment or idea they want to follow. No quotes, no definitions.

### Does it earn its length?

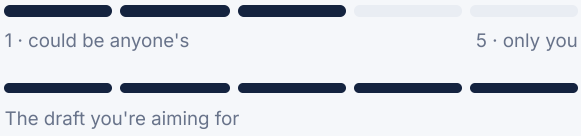
Every paragraph moves it forward. The ending lands without restating the point.

### Does it answer the prompt?

Especially in supplements: the question that was asked, answered throughout, not just in the last line.

### Most drafts score in the middle.

On each question a draft lands somewhere from 1 to 5. Most first drafts sit at 2 or 3. A 5 is rare, and it never comes from a bigger topic: it comes from sharper detail and real thinking.




Notice what isn't on the list: an impressive topic. A Saturday job can carry an essay further than a tragedy, if the thinking is yours.

# Five parts, in roughly this proportion.

Most essays that work share a shape. It's not a formula, just a skeleton to check your draft against.




First line — About how much of a 650-word essay each part takes — Last line

### 1 A moment, not a summary

Start inside something specific: a sound, a sentence someone said, a mistake. The reader shouldn't know the moral yet.

~60 words
The first two sentences

### 2 The detail only you have

What you noticed that someone passing through wouldn't. This is what makes the essay yours.

~160 words
The world, through your eyes

### 3 The turn

The point where what you believed stopped being true, or got more complicated. Most weak essays skip it.

~100 words
Often one short sentence

### 4 What you do differently now

Show the change in action: a decision, a habit, a question you now ask. Don't name the virtue.

~230 words
The heart of the essay

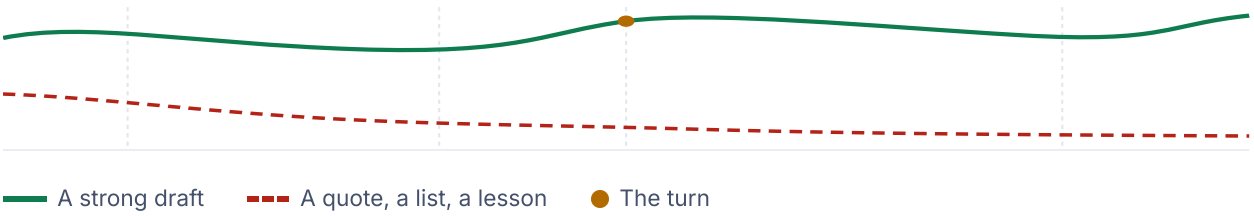
### 5 An ending that lands

Return to an image or leave a question open. Never repeat the lesson or predict your success.

~100 words
Stop one line early

## Where the reader's attention goes

Illustrative



03 · Show, don't announce

# Climb down the ladder.

Abstract claims ask the reader to trust you. Specific details let them see it. Every sentence about yourself sits somewhere on this ladder. Climb down.

VAGUE



SPECIFIC

**Abstract**

"I am a hardworking and responsible person."

**General**

"I worked hard at my grandfather's shop after his stroke."

**Specific**

"I ruined two soles that April and paid for them out of my own envelope, which he noticed and did not mention."

The last one never says "hardworking" or "responsible". It doesn't have to.

## Openings

**INSTEAD OF**

Ever since I was young, I have always been passionate about helping others. As Gandhi said, "Be the change you wish to see in the world."

Tells the moral first, borrows someone else's words.

**TRY**

The left boot always comes in worse. Mrs. Alvarez drags that foot a little, and the heel wears to a slant you can feel with your thumb.

Drops the reader into a moment and makes them wonder.

## Endings

**INSTEAD OF**

This experience taught me the value of hard work, and I know these skills will help me succeed in college and beyond.

Restates the lesson, predicts success. Could end any essay.

**TRY**

"Show me on the other one first," she said, and put her foot up on the bench.

Ends on an action that carries the meaning. Stops early.

# See the five parts at work.

Written for this guide to show the parts in action. Not a real applicant's essay.

The left boot always comes in worse.[1] Mrs. Alvarez drags that foot, a little, and the outside of the heel wears to a slant you can feel with your thumb before you see it. I knew this about her before I knew her first name.

I was fifteen, and my grandfather's left hand had stopped closing the spring before, so the awl was mine now. He sat on the stool by the register and corrected me with his chin.[2] Too deep. Again. I ruined two soles that April and paid for them out of my own envelope, which he noticed and did not mention.

What I liked, it turned out, was the ledger. Forty percent of our Saturday money came from eleven people,[2] and I could tell you which of them walked to work. I raised the price of a heel by two dollars and told my grandfather afterward. He looked at the page for a long time, then pushed it back to me, and I still can't say whether that meant yes.

Mrs. Alvarez could buy new boots. He told me that the first year, and also that her husband had bought these ones, and I took it as a sweet fact about her. I don't anymore.[3] I think she comes in every four months because this is a thing she can still do for him that has a beginning and an end. When I look at a business now I don't ask what it sells. I ask what its eleven people would have to do without.[4]

Last month I told her the left heel couldn't take another nail. She thought about it. "Show me on the other one first," she said, and put her foot up on the bench.[5]

1 **The moment**
Seven words, no context, and the reader is already inside a shop.

2 **The detail only they have**
Nobody invents "corrected me with his chin". A ledger number says more than "I learned business skills".

3 **The turn**
Four words mark where the old belief stopped being true.

4 **The change, in action**
A question they now ask, instead of a virtue they claim.

5 **An ending that lands**
No lesson restated. A small act of trust, and the essay stops.

Where the words go



# What sinks most first drafts.

Nearly every weak essay falls into at least one of these. Each one has a fix you can make in an afternoon.

Trap 1

### The borrowed opening

A famous quote, a dictionary definition, "Ever since I was young". It tells the reader you're about to say what everyone says.

**Fix: cut your first paragraph. Start where the story actually starts.**

Trap 2

### The résumé in paragraphs

Club, captain, volunteer, award. Your activities list already did this, and better.

**Fix: pick one experience and go deep. Cut the rest.**

Trap 3

### The announced lesson

"This taught me that failure is a stepping stone to success." If you have to say it, the essay didn't show it.

**Fix: replace the lesson with what you now do differently.**

Trap 4

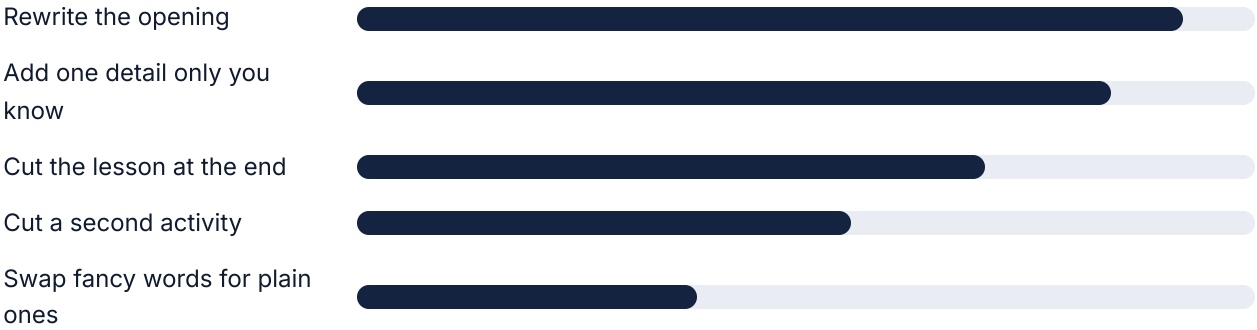
### The thesaurus voice

"Myriad", "invaluable", "plethora". Words you'd never say out loud make you sound like someone else.

**Fix: read it aloud. Rewrite every line you'd never say.**

### Where to spend your next revision

If you only have time for one pass, work down this list. The top fixes change the most.




Our order of priority, not a measurement.

06 · Before you submit

# Ten checks for your draft.

Print this page. Tick each one, or fix it.

- [ ] 1 My first sentence puts the reader in a moment, not a summary of my life.
- [ ] 1 There's no famous quote and no dictionary definition.
- [ ] 2 I couldn't swap my name for a classmate's and keep the essay true.
- [ ] 2 Every claim about myself ("hardworking", "passionate") is shown, or cut.
- [ ] 3 There's a point where something I believed changed, and I can underline it.
- [ ] 4 The change shows up as something I do now, not a lesson I state.
- [ ] 4 I read it aloud and it sounds like me talking to someone I respect.
- [ ] 4 Each paragraph does something the one before it didn't.
- [ ] 5 My last line doesn't repeat the lesson or predict my success.
- [ ] 5 It answers exactly what the prompt asked, and it's under the word limit.


## Want your draft checked against all of this?

Admitted is an AI tool that rates your essay on these six questions, marks the lines costing you most and helps you rewrite them in your own voice.



**admitted.usetrnd.com/essay** · $9.99 a week, cancel anytime